

has been performing satisfactorily. If you forget the names of your wait staff, don't leave the right amount of tip, or accidentally reveal your shopper status, you are putting your reimbursement in danger. I have never had a shopping company not pay me, but I have also been very diligent about doing everything perfectly. If you don't take it seriously, you may not be paid—and you'll be out whatever cash you put into your shopping experience.

### 5. There are other costs involved

In addition to the cost of your shopping (which is usually reimbursed partially or in full), there are other costs. Gas to drive to the shop, the cost (if any) to put an item on your credit card until reimbursement, or the cost of a tip (which is often not covered) are just a few expenses that may come up during a typical shop. Obviously, the best strategy is to shop close, only take shops that reimburse in full (and with an extra shopper's fee, if possible), and turn in your reports on time.

### 6. You are responsible for your own taxes

As a mystery shopper, you are considered an independent contractor. While it is unlikely that you will

earn over \$600 a year for any one company, you will still be responsible for reporting that income on your tax returns. You can count it as self-employment, deducting expenses as needed, so keep track of the cost of your new mystery-shopping job.

### 7. Some mystery shopping isn't shopping or a mystery

Many shopping companies have begun scheduling work for companies that aren't even related to mystery shopping. Audits, merchandising, and other tasks (including headstone cleaning) often come up on the mystery-shopping job boards from time to time. If you don't have an interest in these types of jobs, don't feel obliged to take them. They can be a good source of income for you, however.

### 8. A reputable mystery-shopping company will never ask you for any kind of fee

I'll say this again: You should not have to ever pay for the "privilege" to shop. You are performing a service, and should get paid. Any fee that is guaranteed to get you a list of jobs is bogus. For a genuine listing of most every single shop service on the planet, see Volition.com or check